

Correction/Retraction Escalation SOP - MCN News

Purpose

This document defines how a factual error in a published story is classified, corrected, and - where necessary - escalated and retracted.

Error Classification

- Minor correction: a small factual error that doesn't change the story's core meaning (a misspelled name, a wrong date on a secondary detail, a rounding error in a figure).
- Major correction: an error that materially affects the story's core claim or a named individual's reputation, but the story's overall premise still stands once corrected.
- Retraction: the story's core claim is substantially false or unverifiable - the story cannot stand even in corrected form.

Correction Process

1. Any error is first reported to the Section Editor responsible for the story (via reader report, internal review, or the Fact-Check Desk's retroactive check for breaking news).
2. Minor corrections: Section Editor approves and the correction is applied in-place, with a visible "Corrected on [date]" note appended to the article, within 4 hours of confirmation.
3. Major corrections: requires Editor-in-Chief sign-off in addition to the Section Editor, a visible correction notice at the top of the article (not just an inline edit), and - if the story already aired on TV - an on-air correction read during the next scheduled bulletin.
4. Retractions: require Editor-in-Chief sign-off. The story is replaced with a retraction notice explaining what was wrong and why, the original story is removed from active circulation (search/social promotion), and an on-air retraction is read during the next scheduled bulletin regardless of whether the story aired on TV originally.

Escalation Timing

- Major corrections and retractions must be actioned within 4 hours of confirmation for still-developing stories, or 1 business day for older stories no longer receiving significant traffic.
- Any correction or retraction involving a named individual's reputation additionally requires Legal's review before publication of the correction notice, regardless of classification tier.